

A full-page background image of a muscular man in a gym, performing a chest exercise using a resistance band. He is shirtless, showing his well-defined pectoral and abdominal muscles. He is holding the band with both hands, pulling it towards his chest. The lighting is dramatic, highlighting the contours of his muscles.

THE MUSCLE CODE

BULKING SYSTEM

A RECOV PLAYBOOK

The Muscle *Code*

Secrets to effective bulking — build lean, quality muscle without the fat spillover.

YOUR COACH

Daniel Delahunty

POWERED BY

RECOV

START HERE

Bulking isn't eating more. It's eating *smart*.

There's nothing quite like noticing real change in your body — the first definition in your arms, the sweep in your thighs, the confidence that comes with progress. It's addictive. Soon you want to fill out and look jacked.

That phase — bulking — isn't just about eating more or lifting heavier. It's a science, an art and a mindset. Over the next six chapters we'll unlock the proven strategies behind gaining lean mass efficiently while minimising fat: how to train for growth, how much to eat, how to recover, how to track, and which supplements actually earn their place. Let's build properly.



Daniel Delahunty

YOUR COACH

I'm in my 50s and I still train and build like this every week. I've spent years helping people add quality muscle without wrecking their physique — the smart way, not the reckless way. This is the system I use.

THE SYSTEM AT A GLANCE

Six chapters. One clean, repeatable way to grow.

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CHAPTERS

8–12

WEEK PROGRAM

5

CORE SUPPLEMENTS

Your roadmap to lean mass

1

Bulking Basics

The pillars of intelligent, lean muscle growth.

2

Hypertrophy Training

The 8-12 week resistance-training blueprint.

3

Calculated Gains

Building muscle without the fat spillover.

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The Growth Zone

How recovery & sleep supercharge your bulk.

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From Chaos to Control

The role of tracking in smart bulking.

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Supplementation

Optional but helpful – the five that earn their place.

Bulking Basics

To maximise lean muscle growth, start from a healthy body composition. For most people that means roughly **10–15% body fat for men and 18–23% for women** before beginning a bulk. In that range your body partitions nutrients better — the calories you eat are more likely to be stored in muscle, not fat.

Gaining weight ≠ gaining muscle

True hypertrophy means adding lean tissue, not just watching the scale climb. Overeat — especially carbs — and your body can't store all that energy as muscle glycogen. The overflow spills into fat, slowing progress and making the eventual cut harder. Chronically overshooting can even drive insulin resistance, where muscles absorb glucose and amino acids less efficiently, so excess nutrients end up as fat.

The four pillars

- **Periodisation** — a plan that grows with you, cycling through strength, volume and refinement phases so progress stays steady.
- **Progressive overload** — always give your muscles a reason to adapt: a bit heavier, an extra rep, slower tempo, tighter form.
- **Exercise selection** — build on the big compounds (squats, presses, pulls), then layer isolation work to bring up lagging areas.
- **Rest & recovery** — muscle grows when you rest, not when you lift. Rest between sets, schedule rest days, sleep well.

*The real secret to lean growth:
effective training, calculated
eating, and smart recovery.*

A man with a beard is performing a leg press exercise on a machine in a gym. He is lying on his back with his feet on the machine's platform, pushing the weight up. The machine has large red weight plates. The background shows other gym equipment and a person in the distance.

CHAPTER 02

Hypertrophy Training

This is where gym science meets application — every rep and set turned into growth stimulus. Over the next 8–12 weeks you'll follow an evidence-based plan built around mechanical tension, metabolic stress and muscle damage.

Program overview

Duration	8–12 weeks
Frequency	4–6 training days / week
Split	Upper/Lower or Push/Pull/Legs
Rep range	6–15 reps
Rest	60–120 seconds
Tempo	Controlled eccentric (2–3s), explosive concentric
Progression	Add load or reps weekly

Training principles

- **Volume:** 10–20 sets per muscle group weekly.
- **Intensity:** 65–85% of 1RM — the sweet spot of tension and stress.
- **Rest:** 1–2 min for isolation, 2–3 min for compounds.
- **Proximity to failure:** keep 0–2 reps in reserve (RIR).
- **Progression:** add load or reps each week.

Upper / Lower split — 4 days

Day 1 Upper • Push emphasis

Barbell Bench Press	4 × 6–8
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Heavy compound, progressive overload

Incline Dumbbell Press	3 × 8–10
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Upper chest focus

Seated Shoulder Press	3 × 8–10
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Controlled tempo

Cable Lateral Raise	3 × 12–15
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Strict isolation

Triceps Rope Pushdown	3 × 12–15
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Mind-muscle connection

Day 2 Lower • Quad emphasis

Back Squat	4 × 6–8
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Foundation lift — depth & control

Leg Press	3 × 10–12
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Full range quad overload

Bulgarian Split Squat	3 × 10–12
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Balance & stability

Leg Extension	3 × 12–15
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Eccentric control

Standing Calf Raise	3 × 12–15
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Pause at top

Day 3 Upper • Pull emphasis

Barbell Row Controlled eccentric	4 × 6–8
Pull-Up / Lat Pulldown Wide grip for width	3 × 8–10
Seated Cable Row Squeeze at contraction	3 × 10–12
Dumbbell Rear Delt Fly Posterior shoulder	3 × 12–15
Barbell Curl Controlled lowering	3 × 10–12

Day 4 Lower • Glute / Ham emphasis

Romanian Deadlift Hip hinge — glute & ham	4 × 6–8
Walking Lunges Unilateral balance & stretch	3 × 10–12
Lying Leg Curl Smooth tempo	3 × 10–12
Hip Thrust Full lockout & squeeze	3 × 10–12
Seated Calf Raise Slow eccentric	3 × 12–15

Progression model

- **Weeks 1–4 — Foundation:** moderate load, master technique, stay 2–3 RIR.
- **Weeks 5–8 — Overload:** gradually add weight or reps, 1–2 RIR.
- **Weeks 9–12 — Peak:** high volume, near failure (0–1 RIR). Deload after week 12.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Consistency beats complexity — master the basics.
- Hold a slight surplus (250–500 kcal/day).
- Prioritise 7–9 hours of sleep.
- Track every lift, rep and week.
- Recovery drives growth — train hard, rest harder.

REFERENCES

1. Schoenfeld BJ (2010). Mechanisms of muscle hypertrophy and their application to resistance training. *J Strength Cond Res*.
2. Krieger JW (2010). Single vs. multiple sets for hypertrophy: a meta-analysis. *J Strength Cond Res*.



CHAPTER 03

Calculated Gains

Bulking isn't a licence to eat everything in sight — it's a strategic phase of controlled surplus. Give your body just enough extra energy to fuel new tissue, without tipping into needless fat gain.

Treating a bulk as "massive overeating" is the classic mistake. You need a surplus, but overdoing it stores more fat than muscle — and you'll spend months dieting it off later. The smarter move: know exactly how much extra food you need for lean growth.

Find maintenance, then add a surplus

Start with your maintenance calories — what your body needs to hold its current weight. Estimate it with the Harris-Benedict equation or a free calculator, then add a surplus sized to your experience:

+300–500

BEGINNER KCAL/DAY

+200–300

INTERMEDIATE KCAL/DAY

+100–200

ADVANCED KCAL/DAY

Aim for **0.25–0.5% body-weight gain per week**. An 82 kg athlete should add roughly 0.2–0.4 kg weekly. Faster than that and you're likely storing fat — wind it back.

The macro blueprint

Once calories are set, split them across the three pillars of growth — protein **25–30%**, carbs **50–60%**, fats **15–25%**:

EXAMPLE · 3,000 KCAL MUSCLE-GAIN PLAN

Daily targets

188g

PROTEIN

25% · 750 kcal

413g

CARBS

55% · 1,650 kcal

67g

FATS

20% · 600 kcal

Eat clean, keep inflammation low

Quality matters as much as quantity. Chronic inflammation impairs recovery, blunts growth and increases fat storage — so build meals from whole, minimally processed foods.

INCLUDE

- Lean proteins — chicken, turkey, fish, eggs, Greek yogurt
- Complex carbs — rice, oats, quinoa, sweet potato
- Healthy fats — olive oil, avocado, nuts, fatty fish
- Antioxidant produce — berries, spinach, kale, peppers

LIMIT

- Processed oils — soy, corn, sunflower
- Refined sugars & trans fats
- Excess alcohol
- Deep-fried foods

When eating more feels impossible

As targets rise, appetite often doesn't. Fermented, easily digestible foods — kefir, yogurt, sauerkraut, kimchi, miso, kombucha — improve digestion and absorption so you can handle bigger meals without bloating. Spread food across 4–6 smaller meals, add calorie-dense extras (olive oil, nut butters, oats, smoothies), and stay hydrated.

THE CALCULATED-GAIN FORMULA

- Find your maintenance calories.
- Add a moderate surplus (100–500 kcal by experience).
- Track weekly; adjust if gain exceeds 0.5%/week.
- Balance macros (~25% protein / 55% carbs / 20% fats).
- Prioritise clean, anti-inflammatory foods.
- Support digestion with fermented & whole foods.

The body can only build muscle so fast. Precision and patience beat reckless overeating every time — and leave you with a physique you won't have to diet away.

The Growth Zone

Training is the stimulus, but recovery is the growth. You can lift heavy and eat right, yet without true rest your body never fully rebuilds. Sleep plus smart recovery are the real secret weapons of any successful bulk.

The real growth process

When you train, you break muscle down. When you rest, you build it back stronger. During recovery your body repairs fibres through protein synthesis, rebalances hormones like testosterone, GH and IGF-1, refills glycogen, and clears inflammation and fatigue. Skip it and you're just layering fatigue on fatigue.

*You don't grow in the gym —
you grow between sessions.*

Sleep: your natural anabolic

Deep sleep is when the body releases growth hormone and resets the nervous system — no supplement replaces it. Aim for seven to nine solid hours; it's the cheapest performance enhancer there is.

QUICK SLEEP CHECKLIST

- Set bedtime and wake time.
- Dark, cool, quiet room.
- Avoid screens and caffeine late in the day.
- Slow protein before bed (casein or Greek yogurt) for overnight repair.

The recovery pyramid

- **Tier 1 · Sleep quality** — the foundation; consistent sleep means optimal hormone release.
- **Tier 2 · Nutrition timing** — fuel the rebuild: 25–40g protein + carbs post-workout, slow protein before bed. Fast-absorbed aminos right after training top up recovery the moment your body is most primed — that's exactly where Recov fits.
- **Tier 3 · Active recovery & sauna** — light movement plus heat (2–3×/week) to boost circulation, activate heat-shock proteins and ease soreness.
- **Tier 4 · Stress control** — high stress spikes cortisol, the enemy of growth. Use breath-work, journaling or quiet walks.

Don't ignore overtraining

When fatigue outweighs recovery, progress stalls — watch for persistent soreness, flat lifts, irritability or insomnia. The fix isn't weakness, it's strategy: plan deloads of 3–5 lighter days every 6–8 weeks.



Train to break down. Sleep to rebuild. Recover to grow.

REFERENCE

Saner NL, et al. (2020). The effect of sleep restriction, with or without high-intensity interval exercise, on myofibrillar protein synthesis in healthy young men. *The Journal of Physiology*. PMID: 32078168.

CHAPTER 05

From Chaos to Control

You can lift hard, eat "a lot," and still spin your wheels. Without tracking you're guessing — not growing. Smart bulking is about precision: tracking turns effort into measurable progress and gives you control over the chaos.

Tracking = awareness = control

When you track, you see what's actually happening — not what you think is. It gives you clarity on calories, macros and lifts; accountability (numbers don't lie); early adjustments before stalls become setbacks; and visible progress you'll want to repeat.

What to track

Nutrition	Calories, protein, carbs, fats — drives gain, controls fat
Training	Exercises, sets, reps, weights — ensures overload
Body metrics	Weight, photos, waist — lean vs. fat gain
Recovery	Sleep, stress, energy — keeps performance high

Nutrition: the foundation

- 1 **Find maintenance** — track intake 1–2 weeks; stable weight = maintenance.
- 2 **Add a surplus** — +250–500 calories/day to start.
- 3 **Set macros** — protein 1–1.2g per lb bodyweight, fat 20–25% of calories, carbs fill the rest.

Tools like MyFitnessPal, MacroFactor or a simple logbook are plenty. Tracking now teaches you how to eat instinctively later.

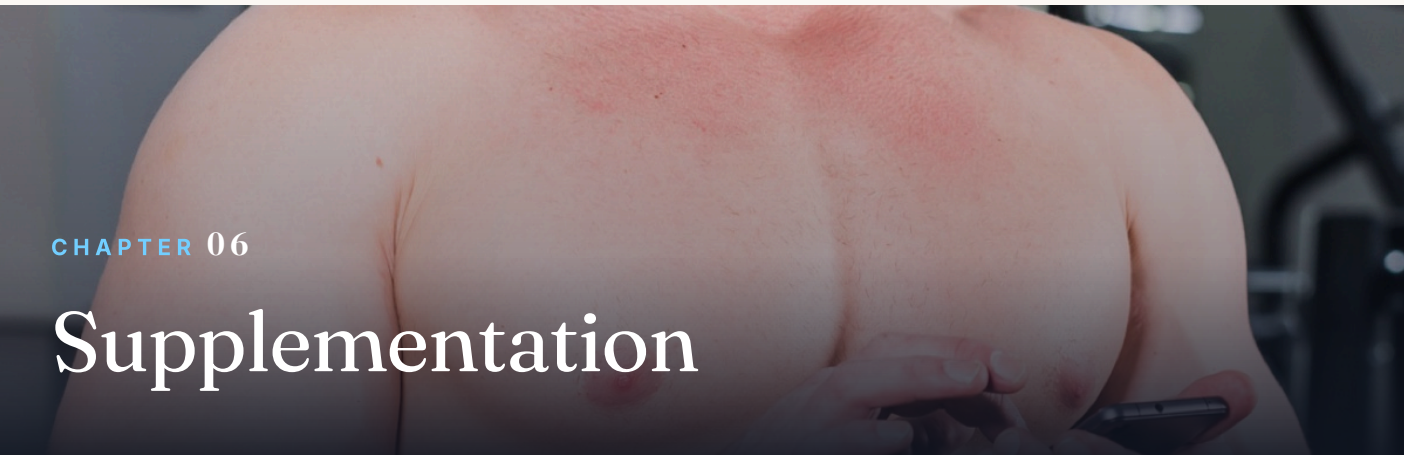
What the scale can't tell you

Numbers alone don't tell the full story — pair data with visuals. Weigh daily and average weekly, take photos every 2–4 weeks, measure waist and arms monthly. Not moving? Add 150–250 calories. Climbing too fast? Pull back. Growth should be steady, not sloppy.

AVOID THESE MISTAKES

- Guessing portions — accuracy matters.
- Over-tracking — perfection kills consistency.
- Changing plans weekly — give adjustments time.
- Ignoring recovery — data means nothing if you're exhausted.

What gets measured gets mastered.



CHAPTER 06

Supplementation

Supplements aren't steroids, and they won't save a bad diet or sloppy training. But when your meals, sleep and lifting are locked in, the right few give you an edge — push harder, recover faster, grow leaner. Here are five science-backed, bang-for-buck foundations.

1

Protein Isolates and Concentrates

Clean, fast-digesting, and perfect for hitting your daily protein without stuffing your face all day.

Use: 6–8 tablets or 1–2 scoops post-workout or between meals · PMID 35871954

2

Creatine Monohydrate

The most proven supplement there is — decades of evidence for strength, power and muscle fullness. More weight moved = more growth.

Use: 5g every day, consistently · PMID 39519498

3

Omega-3 Fish Oil (EPA/DHA)

Joint lube and recovery juice — keeps inflammation down, helps muscles repair, may support protein synthesis.

Use: 1–3g combined EPA/DHA daily with meals · PMID 21159787

4

Vitamin D3 + K2

Most people run low on D, especially indoors. Low D means lower strength and worse recovery; K2 helps your body use calcium properly.

Use: 2,000–4,000 IU D3 + a small K2 (MK-7) dose daily · PMID 32831908

5

Zinc + Magnesium

Quiet workhorses — zinc supports healthy testosterone, magnesium keeps muscles firing and improves sleep.

Use: one ZMA-style combo before bed · PMID 8875519 / 20352370

You can't out-supplement a bad bulk. But if you're training like a savage, eating like a pro and recovering like a champ, these five keep your gains clean and your energy high.

Train hard. Eat smart. Recover harder.

RECOVER FASTER

The recovery half of the equation

Training breaks you down; recovery builds you back. The fastest way to feed a freshly-trained muscle is amino acids it can absorb immediately — that's the gap Recov fills, right alongside the protein and creatine in your stack.



Recov

The science-led recovery formula

- All 20 amino acids — the full set your body needs
- Pre-digested & absorbed in ~15–20 minutes
- Ideal post-workout and before bed
- No bloat — built by a scientist, formulation first

Build it. Then recover like you mean it.

Run the program, dial in the food, and give your recovery the same precision. Start your first bottle of Recov.

[Shop Recov →](#)

[Learn more](#)

Train the program alongside Recov. If your recovery doesn't feel sharper, we'll make it right — just reach out.

Want Daniel to build your bulk for you? He coaches a small number of clients each intake — details inside your Recov welcome email.



The Muscle Code — Secrets to Effective Bulking

with Daniel Delahunty

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